

READING ARCHITECTURE THROUGH ANG LARAWAN (FILM REVIEW/ CO2 REFLECTIVE WRITING)

*“Itong huling Oktubre sa bahay na ito
Lubusang maglalaho ang lahat ng ito
Paalam nang tuluyan
Sa bawat gunita ng dati nating buhay
Na ano't nawala*

*Kailangan daw magbago ang ikot ng mundo
Upang maligtas ang buhay
Kailangang mamatay
Paalam nang tuluyan
Sa bawat gunita ng dati nating buhay
Na ano't nawala...”*

This song, sung by Candida as she faces the possible loss of her family’s home, captures the true soul of *Ang Larawan*. For me, the song expresses the pain of saying goodbye not only to a physical house, but also to the memories, identity, and way of life connected to it. Through the song, I could feel the sadness of holding on to the past while being forced to accept inevitable change.

Ang Larawan is a Filipino musical film centered on sisters Candida and Paula Marasigan, who continue living in their old ancestral house in Intramuros while struggling with financial problems and pressure from others to sell the property. As I watched the film, I realized that it is not only about family, art, and sacrifice, but also about memory, heritage, and change. More than just a setting, the ancestral house becomes an important part of the story because it carries the history, identity, and emotions of the family.

From my perspective as an architecture student, the Bahay na Bato in the film is more than just a background structure. I see it as a reflection of the emotional and social condition of the people living in it. Its architectural features such as high ceilings, wide ventanillas, capiz shell windows, thick stone walls, and a spacious sala mayor were originally designed for comfort, natural ventilation, family gatherings, and social traditions. To me, these elements represent the elegance and lifestyle of an earlier period in Philippine history.

However, the film gives these architectural features a different meaning. The large sala mayor, where Candida and Paula spend most of their time, emphasizes their loneliness and isolation. Instead of showing wealth and prestige, the empty space makes the sisters appear small and emotionally distant. I noticed how the house, once a symbol of prosperity, now reflects decline and absence. Its size no longer matches the sisters’ difficult financial condition, making the house feel both grand and burdensome at the same time.

One architectural detail that stood out to me was the repeated opening and closing of the windows. Candida and Paula often shut the windows to block out the noise and activity outside, only to reopen them moments later. For me, this simple action carries symbolic meaning. It reflects their uncertain relationship with a society that is rapidly changing and modernizing. The windows act as both protection and barrier. They shield the sisters from the outside world while also

separating them from it. Because of this, I see the house as both a place of comfort and a kind of confinement, keeping them attached to the past.

I also noticed that this conflict between preserving the past and adapting to change is reflected in the character of Don Perico. Once an artist, he later became a congressman, giving up his creative life to fit society's expectations. To me, his transformation does not feel like success, but more like a quiet surrender. Like the Marasigan house, his identity belongs to a world that is slowly disappearing. Through these parallels, the film made me question whether cultural preservation and social progress must always oppose one another.

Relating this to architecture, I realized how architectural styles change over time as society adapts to new realities. The Bahay na Bato represents traditional Filipino architecture, but after the war, many historic buildings and ancestral homes were destroyed or heavily damaged. Some structures could no longer be repaired or restored, which led people to focus on building stronger, more modern, and more practical structures. As newer architectural styles became more common, many traditional houses were slowly abandoned, neglected, or forgotten.

For me, the Marasigan house reflects this reality. Although it is old and deteriorating, it still carries emotional, cultural, and historical value that cannot easily be replaced. The house symbolizes how traditional architecture is often left behind in the pursuit of modernization. At the same time, the film reminded me that these old structures are more than outdated buildings. They are physical connections to history, identity, and memory. In this sense, *Ang Larawan* highlights the importance of preserving heritage architecture even as society continues to progress and develop new forms of design.

Watching the film also reminded me of older houses, especially my Inang's house, which was inherited by my grandmother. It has capiz shell windows, wooden staircases, and interiors that seem to carry the memories of previous generations. Even when empty, the house still feels alive, as though the walls themselves remember the people who once lived there. In the same way, I see the Marasigan house as a vessel of both personal and collective memory.

Ultimately, *Ang Larawan* expanded my understanding of architecture beyond function and appearance. As architecture students, we are often taught to design for the future by focusing on efficiency, innovation, and practicality. However, this film reminded me that architecture also carries memory, identity, and history. The Marasigan house may be old and slowly deteriorating, but it remains valuable and irreplaceable. Its physical decline does not lessen its importance. Instead, the film invites me to reflect on how architecture can preserve the past while still existing within a changing present.